

In the General Preferences, you will notice the text box that says “History States.” Photoshop’s History tracks the changes made to an image, letting you revert to any state. While it does sound like a glorified undo stack, there’s a lot more to the History



## The Preferences Dialog

than that, as we'll see later. Photoshop saves 20 History states by default, but you can go as high as 1,000. The History states occupy precious memory and disk space, though, so use it with caution.

The next thing you need to look at is how your tools are going to look inside Photoshop. From the drop-down list on the top left, select “Display & Cursors”. Under Painting Cursors, choose “Full Size Brush Tip”—this way, when you’re using any of the paintbrushes, you get an accurate idea of the shape and size of the brush, letting you paint with greater ease. Under Other Cursors, choose Precise, so that drawing selections and colour picking becomes much more, well, precise.

The next thing you need to guide Photoshop to is Scratch Disks. When Photoshop runs out of RAM, it uses your hard disk as temporary storage, much like virtual memory. By default, the primary scratch disk is the one where Windows is installed—you should change that in a hurry. Ideally, your primary scratch disk should be on a separate hard disk altogether, and should:

1. Have loads of free space
2. Be your fastest disk
3. Be defragmented often